Have you submitted your request for time off?

Imperative Mood

Use the **imperative mood** to give instructions and commands. The subject, *you*, is often implied but not stated:

(You) Use the online form to request time off.

(You) Submit your request for time off by Friday.

You must submit your request on time.

Subjunctive Mood

Use the **subjunctive mood** to express wishes, suggestions, or requirements or to state hypothetical or unlikely conditions:

The rules state that every member be present for the vote.

I wish you were here to see the exhibition.

The governing board could be more effective if all members were active.

Students who failed the class would have passed had they completed all assignments.

H 8. Pronouns

A **Pronouns** is a word used in place of a noun. Some pronouns are *I, you, he, she, we, they, who,* and *everyone*. The noun a pronoun replaces or refers to is its **antecedent**. (See Editing Focus: Pronouns for a related discussion of pronouns.)

Pronoun Reference

A pronoun should refer to a clear and specific antecedent.

Clear Antecedent All nine members of the school board voted in favor of changing the district's mascot. They explained their reasoning during the meeting. (*They* refers clearly to *members.*)

Unclear Antecedent In Smith's essay, she explains why many American families have less money saved and more debt than families in the 1970s.

Revised In her essay, Smith explains why many American families have less money saved and more debt than families in the 1970s.

Problems with pronoun reference occur in the following situations:

Vague *this, that, which,* or *it.* The pronouns *this, that, which,* and *it* should not refer to words expressing an idea, an event, or a situation.

Vague Reference The school board voted to change the district's mascot without holding special meetings with the public. This made some community members angry. (*Are community members angry about the vote or about the lack of special meetings?*)

Revised The school board voted to change the district's mascot without holding special meetings with the public. Their decision to avoid public discussion before the vote made some community members angry.

Indefinite *it, they,* or *you.* The pronouns *it, they,* and *you* should have a definite antecedent in a sentence.

Indefinite *it* Crittenden explains that mothers are taken for granted and disrespected, even though our society calls it the most important job in the world.

Revised Crittenden explains that mothers are taken for granted and disrespected, even though our

society calls motherhood the most important job in the world.

Indefinite *they* Japan has considerable wealth compared to Ireland, but they have a low subjective well-being index.

Revised Japan has considerable wealth compared to Ireland, but Japanese citizens have a low subjective well-being index.

Indefinite *you* The federal government should raise the minimum wage to ensure you earn a wage you can live on.

Revised The federal government should raise the minimum wage to ensure workers earn a wage they can live on.

Pronoun-Antecedent Agreement

In many sentences, making a pronoun agree with its antecedent is straightforward: *My neighbors gave me the keys to their apartment.* However, pronoun-antecedent agreement gets tricky in the following circumstances.

Agreement with Generic Nouns and Indefinite Pronouns

Generic nouns refer to a type of person or job someone performs, such as *athlete, child, scientist, doctor,* or *hairdresser*. **Indefinite pronouns** include words such as *anyone, each, everyone, everything, many, most,* and *none.*

All generic nouns and most indefinite pronouns are singular in meaning. Traditionally, these words took the singular pronouns *he/him/his* because English does not have a gender-neutral third-person pronoun that refers to people: *Everyone has his own opinion* or *A doctor needs to show that he cares about his patients.*

More recently, writers have been replacing *he/him/his* or *his/her* with *they/them/their* when the person's gender is unknown or unimportant or when the person has indicated a preference for non-gendered pronouns:

Everyone has their own opinion.

A doctor needs to show that they care about their patients.

These plural pronouns are increasingly accepted and intentionally used by writers, teachers, and editors. Many prominent publications and style guides indicate that the plural pronoun should replace binary or singular ones in most cases. If using a plural pronoun does not fit the situation (such as in a paragraph where the pronoun they is also used several times to indicate a group), try rewriting the sentence in either of these ways:

Remove the pronoun. *Everyone has an opinion.*

Make the antecedent plural. *People have their own opinions. Doctors need to show that they care about their patients.*

Agreement with Collective Nouns

Collective nouns such as *audience, band, class, crowd, family, group,* or *team* can take a singular or plural pronoun depending on the context. When the group acts as a single unit, which is the most common construction, use a singular pronoun. When the group members act individually, use a plural pronoun. If using the plural sounds awkward, add the word *members* so that the plural is clear.

The band went through its complete playlist.

The band loaded their instruments on the bus. The band members loaded their instruments on the bus.

Pronoun Case

Pronouns have three cases: subjective, objective, and possessive. Pronouns change case according to their function in a sentence.

- **Subjective case pronouns** function as subjects: *I, we, you, he/she/it, they, who/whoever*:

  Antonio and I share an apartment downtown in a neighborhood we like.

- **Objective case pronouns** function as objects: *me, us, you, him/her/it, them, whom/whomever*:

  The manager gave us a tour of the building.

- **Possessive case pronouns** show ownership: *my/mine, our/ours, your/yours, his/her/hers/its, their/theirs, whose*:

  Our friends live in the building too.

Pronoun case gets tricky in the circumstances explained below.

Case in Compound Structures

Compound subjects use subjective case pronouns. **Compound objects** use objective case pronouns.

Subjective Case Antonio and I have occasional disagreements about the dishes.

Objective Case Occasional disagreements about the dishes come up between Antonio and me.

Case After *than* or *as*

In a comparison, the case of the pronoun indicates which words have been left out:

Antonio cares more about having a clean kitchen than I [do].

Sometimes I think Antonio cares more about a clean kitchen than [he cares about] me.

Who or *Whom*

Use the **subjective case** *who* in place of a subject—whether it is the subject of the sentence or the subject of a clause:

Who is going to the concert? (subject of sentence)

Give the tickets to whoever can use them. (subject of clause)

She is the person who is best qualified for the job. (subject of clause)

She is the person who I think is best qualified for the job. (subject of clause; the intervening words "I think" don't change the subject or verb of the clause)

Use the **objective case** *whom* in place of an object, whether it is the object of a verb, preposition, or clause:

I don't know whom to ask. (object of verb)

To whom should I give the extra concert tickets? (object of preposition)

Give the tickets to whomever you choose. (object of clause)

We or *us* with a Noun

Use *we* with a subject. Use *us* with an object.

We citizens must vote in order to make our voices heard. (subject)

Legislators need to hear from us citizens. (object)

Case Before or After an Infinitive

Use the objective case before and after an **infinitive** (the *to* form of a verb: *to run, to walk, to eat*):

The agent asked Antonio and me to write a review.

We agreed to give him a positive review.

Case Before a Gerund

Generally, use the possessive case of a pronoun before a **gerund** (the *-ing* form of a verb used as a noun: *gentle snoring, elegant dining*):

He grew tired of their partying late into the night.

The rental agreement depends on your approving the lease terms.

H 9. Punctuation

This section covers the major marks of punctuation: commas, apostrophes, semicolons, colons, periods, question marks, exclamation points, dashes, and parentheses. (For using brackets and ellipses, see Quotations.)

Commas

Commas alert readers to brief pauses within sentences.

Commas with Main Clauses

Use a comma before a coordinating conjunction (*for, and, nor, but, or, yet,* or *so)* joining main clauses:

Businesses in the metropolitan area are growing**,** and unemployment is down.

Many job seekers use online sites like Indeed.com**,** but a few still send traditional cover letters and résumés through the mail.

A solution must be determined soon**,** or the problem will continue.

Commas with Introductory Information

Use a comma after an introductory element at the start of a sentence:

After class is over**,** we should get lunch and review our notes.

Shuffling his feet nervously**,** he waited for the train.

However**,** the circumstances have not changed.

Commas with Nonessential and Essential Information

(See Editing Focus: Commas with Nonessential and Essential Information for a related discussion of commas.)

Nonessential information refers to information that is usually *not* necessary to the basic meaning of a sentence. Nonessential information is set off by commas. In the following sentence, the word *original* tells readers which labs no longer meet the needs of the teachers and students. The underlined information adds information but does not change the meaning of the sentence and thus is nonessential to the basic meaning:

The original technical education labs**,** which were installed 50 years ago**,** no longer meet the needs of the teachers and students.

Essential information, on the other hand, is necessary to the meaning of the sentence. In following example, the word *original* is no longer part of the sentence; the underlined words convey necessary information about the labs: